

Sermon Centered Service

prc-sermon-centered-service

Worship Style · Service Design · practice · unanimous_lineages

DISPUTED

Supported across the whole Bible
Subject named directly in Scripture
No NT manuscript apparatus applies

Statement under examination

Christian worship rightly centers on the public reading and preaching of Scripture, alongside prayer, song, and the Lord's Supper.

In plain language

The texts behind this question all show worship made up of several activities done together. In Nehemiah 8 Ezra brings out the book of the law (torah) and reads (qara) it aloud to the whole assembly from morning until midday, while Levites give the sense (sekel) so the people understand (bin) what is read. Reading and explaining sit side by side. The two letters to Timothy command devotion to the public reading (anagnosis), to exhortation (paraklesis), and to teaching (didaskalia), and they command preaching (kerysso, to herald or announce) the word (logos) in season and out of season with patience and instruction (didache). So the words clearly attest public reading and preaching as real parts of the gathering. The harder part of the question is the word 'centers'. The claim says worship rightly centers on reading and preaching, with the other practices alongside. Here the words give less help, and it is worth being precise about why. In Acts 2:42 four practices are listed (teaching, fellowship or koinonia, the breaking of the bread, and the prayers), each with its own little word for 'the', joined only by 'and' (kai), with no marker that ranks teaching above the prayers or the breaking of bread. The text presents them in a row, not a stack. In Acts 20:7 the disciples gather 'to break bread' (klasai artou), which is the stated reason for the meeting, and Paul's long talk (logos) happens within that gathering rather than being named as its center. In 1 Corinthians 14:26 each member brings a psalm (psalmos), a teaching (didache), a revelation, a tongue, or an interpretation, and the rule given is that all things be done 'for building up' (pros oikodomen, for edification), naming a goal rather than a single centering act. In Colossians 3:16 the word (logos) of Christ dwelling richly and teaching one another in psalms, hymns, and spiritual songs (odai) are bound together in one sentence. So the words clearly support that reading, preaching, prayer, the breaking of bread, and song are all genuine parts of Christian worship. But the words do not by themselves rank these elements or say that one of them holds first place. For that reason the result here is disputed, strong on the presence of each element but unable to fix their relative weight from the language alone.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
H0543	אָמֵן	amen	amen	
H0995	בִּין	bin	to understand	160
H5971	עַם	am	people	
H6567	פָּרַשׁ	parash	to declare	5
H7121	קָרָא	qara	to call	739
H7922	שֵׂכַל	sekel	understanding	16

H8451	תּוֹרָה	torah	instruction	204
G0103	ᾄδω	ado	to sing	5
G0320	ἀνάγνωσις	anagnosis	reading	3
G0740	ἄρτος	artos	bread	99
G1319	διδασκαλία	didaskalia	teaching	21
G1322	διδαχή	didache	teaching	31
G1651	ἐλέγχω	elegchō	to rebuke	
G2008	ἐπιτιμάω	epitimaō	to rebuke	
G2784	κηρύσσω	kerysso	to preach	64
G2800	κλάσις	klasis	breaking	2
G2806	κλάω	klao	to break	14
G2842	κοινωνία	koinonia	participation	19
G3056	λόγος	logos	word	339
G3870	παρακαλέω	parakaleo	to plead/comfort	117
G3874	παράκλησις	paraklēsis	encouragement	
G4335	προσευχή	proseuche	prayer	37
G4337	προσέχω	prosecho	to watch out	29
G4342	προσκαρτερέω	proskartereo	to continue in/with	11
G5568	ψαλμός	psalmos	psalm	7
G5603	ὕδῃ	ode	song	7

Plain meanings: STEP Bible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

Each named activity is lexically attested as a real corporate practice. Nehemiah 8:1 to 8:8 records the public reading of the law (torah) paired with exposition that yields understanding. Acts 2:42 lists apostolic teaching, fellowship, the breaking of bread, and the prayers. 1 Timothy 4:13 commands public reading (anagnosis), exhortation (paraklesis), and teaching (didaskalia). 2 Timothy 4:2 commands 'preach the word' (kerysson ton logon, an ongoing command to herald or announce the message). Colossians 3:16 with 1 Corinthians 14:26 adds song and psalms as corporate elements. What the words do not establish is the proportional claim carried by 'centers'. Acts 2:42 coordinates four practices in parallel datives (nouns in the 'to-X' grammatical form) joined by 'and' (kai) with no comparative, superlative, or ordinal marker. Acts 20:7 names 'to break bread' (klasai arton) as the purpose-infinitive (the 'in order to' verb form) of the gathering, with Paul's 'word' (logos) following within that purpose. The constituent claim is well attested. The centering claim is underdetermined by the vocabulary.

Scripture

Neh.8.1 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. H8451 תּוֹרָה; H5971A עַם.

Reasoning. All the assembled people gather as one and ask Ezra to bring the book of the law (torah) for public reading. The corporate scope, 'all the people' (kol haam) gathered 'as one man' (keish echad), frames Scripture reading as a congregational act rather than a private one.

Neh.8.3 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. H7121 קרא, H8451 תנא.

Reasoning. Ezra reads (qara, here in the form wayyiqra in Nehemiah 8:3) from the law (torah) from morning until midday before the men, the women, and all who could understand ('the ones understanding', mebinim). The ears of all the people were attentive to the book. Sustained public reading occupies the gathering, and the hearers' attentiveness is highlighted.

Neh.8.8 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. H7121 קרא, H6567 פרש; H7922 שכל.

Reasoning. They read in the book, in the law of God ('the torah of God'), 'made distinct or clear' (meporash, a Pual participle (a Hebrew passive-intensive verb form) of parash meaning to make distinct or clear), and 'giving the sense' (sekel), so that the people understood (bin, to perceive or discern) the reading. Reading is paired with explanation that yields comprehension, the lexical core of preaching as exposition.

Neh.8.6 · neutral · genre: narrative

Key terms. H0543 אמן.

Reasoning. Ezra blesses Yahweh, and the people answer 'truly, truly' (Amen, Amen), lifting their hands and bowing in worship. Prayer and bodily worship accompany the reading, showing multiple practices interwoven within one gathering rather than reading alone.

1Tim.4.13 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4337 προσέχω, G0320 ἀνάγνωσις, G1319 διδασκαλία, G3874 παράκλησις

Reasoning. Until I come, 'devote yourself' (prosece, an ongoing active command in the present tense) 'to the public reading' (te anagnosei), 'to exhortation' (te paraklese), 'to teaching' (te didaskalia). Three datives (nouns in the 'to-X' grammatical form) joined by repeated articles ('the') mark three standing components of the gathered ministry as co-objects of one imperative (one command). Reading, exhortation, and teaching share one verbal command.

2Tim.4.2 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2784 κηρύσσω, G3056 λόγος, G1322 διδασχί

Reasoning. 'Preach' (keryxon, a completed-action command in the aorist tense from kerysso, to herald or announce) 'the word' (ton logon), be ready in season and out of season, 'reprove' (elegxon, expose or convict), 'rebuke' (epitimeson, sharply correct), 'exhort' (parakaleson, urge or encourage) with all patience and 'teaching' (didache). The proclamation of the word is commanded as a defining ministerial act paired with teaching, but as a charge to Timothy as evangelist, not a script for the relative weight of elements in the corporate gathering.

Acts.2.42 · complicates · genre: narrative

Key terms. G4342 προσκαρτερέω, G1322 διδασχί, G2842 κοινωνία, G2800 κλάσις, G4335 προσευχή

Reasoning. 'They were devoting themselves' (esan proskarterountes, a periphrastic imperfect (a 'were-doing' construction expressing ongoing past action)) 'to the teaching' (te didache) of the apostles, 'and the fellowship' (te koinonia), 'the breaking of the bread' (te klasei tou artou), 'and the prayers' (tais proseuchais). Four datives (nouns in the 'to-X' grammatical form), each governed by its own article ('the', appearing as te, te, te, tais), are joined to one participle by two 'and' coordinators (kai) with no comparative or superlative marker. Lexically the four stand in parallel, which complicates a claim that any one is the structural center.

Acts.20.7 · complicates · genre: narrative

Key terms. G2806 κλάω, G0740 ἄρτος, G3056 λόγος

Reasoning. On the first of the week, 'when we were gathered' (syneghmenon hemon, a genitive absolute (a 'while-X' background clause)) 'to break bread' (klasai arton, a completed-action infinitive of purpose meaning 'in order to break bread'), Paul 'was discoursing with them' (dielegeto, ongoing past action of reasoning or dialoguing) and 'prolonged the word' (parateinen ton logon) until midnight. The infinitive 'to break bread' (klasai arton) names the purpose of the gathering, with Paul's 'word' (logos) occurring within that purpose rather than being named as the center.

Col.3.16 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G3056 λόγος, G5568 ψαλμός, G5603 ᾠδή, G0103 ᾄδω

Reasoning. 'Let the word of Christ dwell in you richly' (ho logos tou Christou enoikeito en hymin plousios), teaching and admonishing one another 'in psalms, hymns, and spiritual songs' (psalmois, hymnois, odais pneumatikais), 'singing' (adontes) with grace in your hearts to God. The verse pairs word-rich indwelling with mutual teaching expressed through song, lexically binding word and song together rather than ranking one over the other.

1Cor.14.26 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5568 ψαλμός, G1322 διδασκία

Reasoning. 'When you come together' (hotan synerchesthe), each one has 'a psalm' (psalmon), 'a teaching' (didachen), a revelation, a tongue, an interpretation; let all things be done 'for building up' (pros oikodomen, for edification or upbuilding). Five elements are coordinated as items each member brings to the gathering, with edification as the goal. The vocabulary names goal but not a single centering element.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Neh.8.2	Deut.31.11	tsk	1
1Tim.4.13	Deut.17.19	tsk	1
Neh.8.7	Lev.10.11	tsk	1
Neh.8.8	Hab.2.2	tsk	1
Neh.8.6	1Chr.29.20	tsk	1
Acts.2.42	Acts.20.7	openbible	1
1Tim.4.13	Col.3.16	openbible	1
2Tim.4.2	1Cor.14.26	openbible	1

Complicating texts

Acts.2.42 · addressed

The verse lists four practices in coordinated datives (nouns in the 'to-X' grammatical form), each carrying its own article 'the' ('to the teaching' te didache, 'to the fellowship' te koinonia, 'to the breaking of the bread' te klasei tou artou, 'to the prayers' tais proseuchais), joined to a single periphrastic participle 'were devoting themselves' (proskarterountes, ongoing past action) by two 'and' coordinators (kai). There is no comparative, superlative, or ordinal marker ranking teaching above the others. Lexically the four stand in parallel, so the text supports their joint presence but does not by itself establish that reading and preaching center the gathering. This bounds the verdict to disputed rather than a clean affirmation of the centering claim.

1Cor.14.26 · addressed

Five activities are coordinated as items each member brings to the gathering ('a psalm' psalmon, 'a teaching' didachen, 'a revelation' apokalypsin, 'a tongue' glossan, 'an interpretation' hermeneian), and the controlling clause 'let all things be done for building up' (panta pros oikodomen ginestho) names edification (building up) as the goal of all of them. The lexemes set teaching alongside song, revelation, tongue, and interpretation without ranking, and they fix the criterion as 'building up' (oikodome) rather than as a single centering element. The vocabulary therefore underdetermines a centering claim while affirming the breadth of constituent elements.

Acts.20.7 · addressed

The genitive absolute (a 'while-X' background clause) 'when we were gathered' (syneghmenon hemon) 'to break bread' (klasai artou) makes 'to break bread' (klasai artou) the stated purpose-infinitive (the 'in order to' verb form) of the gathering on the first day of the week, with Paul's 'was discoursing' (dielegeito) and 'prolonged the word' (parateinen ton logon) occurring within that purpose. The lexical pressure runs against the proposition that the sermon names the center of the gathering, while still affirming that proclamation occupies its proceedings.

Concordance traversed

G2784, G0320, G4337, G1319, G1322, G3056, G4335, G4342, G2842, G2800, G2806, G0740, G3870, G2008, G1651, G5568, G5603, G0103, H8451, H7121, H0995, H6567, H7922

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: n/a

Bundle reports not_in_ecm_scope (outside the scope of the ECM apparatus, the critical edition of New Testament textual variants) true and supplies no variant units. The Acts 2:42 reading carries a diacritic at 'fellowship' (koinonia) in the SBLGNT apparatus reflecting punctuation variation between 'to the fellowship to the breaking' (te koinonia te klasei) and 'to the fellowship, to the breaking' (te koinonia, te klasei), but neither punctuation alters the presence and parallelism of the four datives (nouns in the 'to-X' grammatical form), and no cited verse turns on a contested reading for this verdict.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. elements_of_worship, regulative_principle, edification_principle

analogia scripturae invoked · progressive revelation factor

elements_of_worship: for · Reading each anchor as listing constituent worship activities, the lexemes for reading ('public reading' anagnosis, 'to read or call' qara), exposition ('to make distinct' parash, 'insight or sense' sekel, 'to understand' bin), teaching ('teaching' didache, 'instruction' didaskalia), proclamation ('to herald' kerysso), prayer ('prayer' proseuche), breaking of bread ('the breaking of the bread' klasis tou artou, 'to break bread' klasai artou), and song ('psalm' psalmos, 'song' ode, 'to sing' ado) are all present across both testaments. The constituent claim is well attested.

proportion_or_primacy: disputed · Reading the claim as asserting that reading and preaching hold structural primacy over the other elements, the lexemes provide no comparative or superlative marker ranking them above prayer, song, or the Supper. Acts 2:42 coordinates four practices without hierarchy, 1 Corinthians 14:26 coordinates five with 'building up' (oikodome, edification) as goal, and Acts 20:7 names 'to break bread' (klasai artou) as the purpose-infinitive (the 'in order to' verb form) of the gathering. A primacy claim is not lexically fixed.

edification_principle: neutral · Reading the claim through the criterion 'let all things be done for building up' (panta pros oikodomen ginestho) of 1 Corinthians 14:26, the words name edification (building up) as the controlling goal of every gathered element rather than naming a single centering act. On this lens the proposition is neither affirmed nor denied, since centering and edification are different lexical claims.

The verdict hinges on which reading of the stem (the question's wording) is in view. Constituent presence is affirmable across both testaments. Proportional centering is not. That divergence yields a disputed result on the stem as worded.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: yes

Neutralized form. Christian worship in the cited texts includes the public reading and exposition of Scripture together with prayer, the breaking of bread, song, and other corporate acts. The lexical pattern attests these as constituent practices without fixing their relative proportion.

The phrase 'rightly centers on' embeds two layered verdicts in the stem (the question's wording), a normative judgment carried by 'rightly' and a proportional ranking carried by 'centers'. The lexical store can attest the presence of each named element but cannot by itself establish a hierarchy or proportion among them, and it cannot adjudicate the normative 'rightly'. The verdict is derived on the original stem and lands at disputed because the constituent claim is supportable while the centering claim is not lexically demonstrable.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes	Neh.8.8
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes	H6567
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0320
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Acts.2.42
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Acts.20.7
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Col.3.16
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Cor.14.26
interlinear	STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes	1Tim.4.13
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	1Tim.4.13
cross_ref	OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes	Acts.2.42

License audit

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Source	License	Redistribute
OSHB-morphology	CC-BY-4.0	yes
STEPBible-TBESH	CC-BY-4.0	yes
STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes
MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes
STEPBible-TAGNT	CC-BY-4.0	yes
TSK	public_domain	yes
OpenBible-cross-refs	CC-BY	yes

Flags

lexically-disputed